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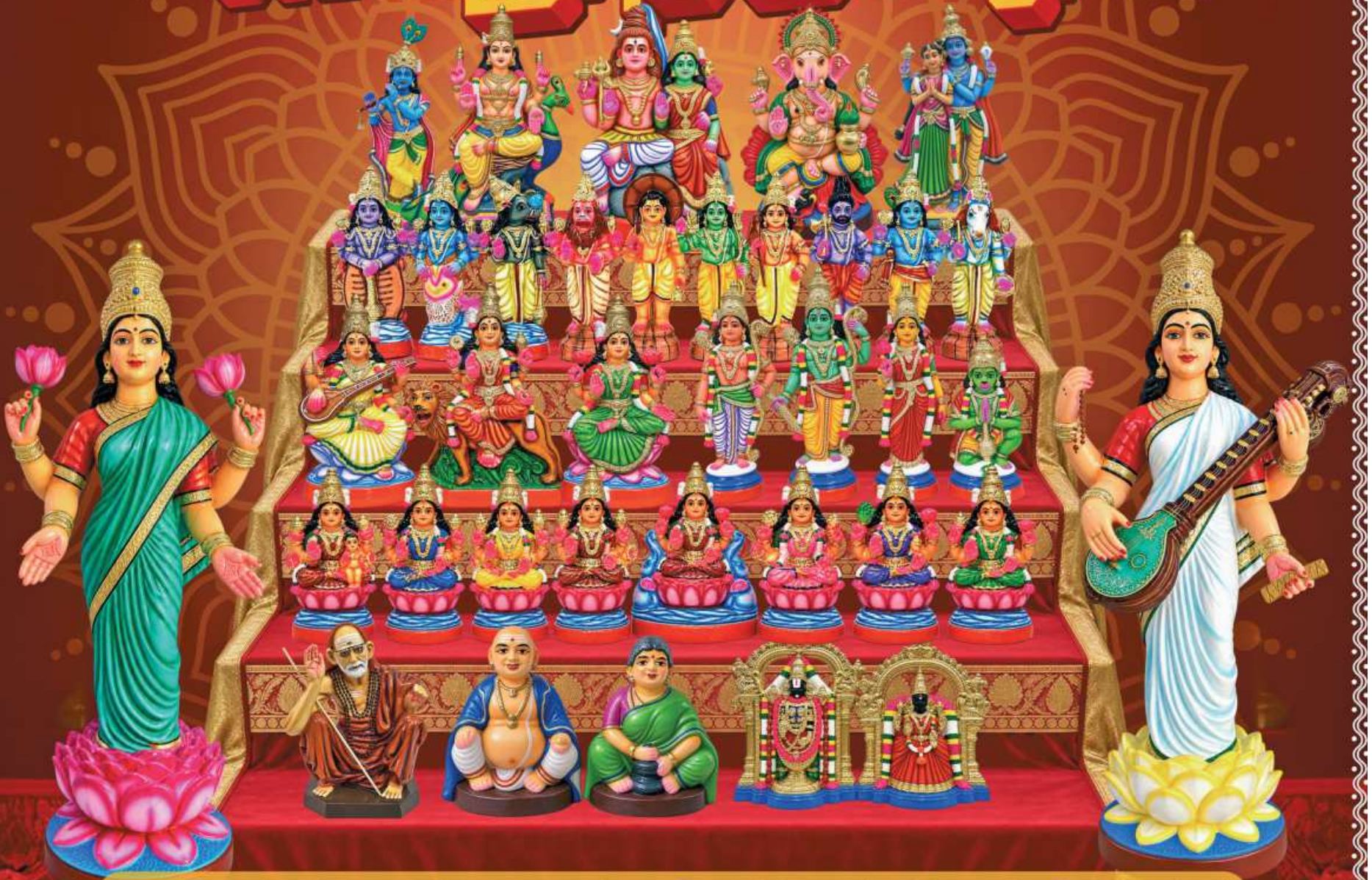
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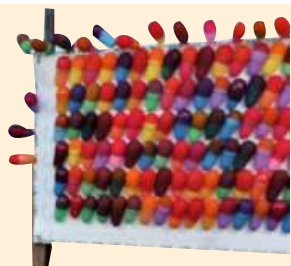
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TAKING A SHOT AT A RARE AVOCATION

Dealers of airguns in Chennai note that enthusiasts of recreational airgun target shooting are on the rise **P3**

Drop your old, unused resources at these spots

'Resource Revival Drive' organised by EcoKconnectors and Spreco is happening on September 27 at various locations in and around Mylapore



Representational picture.

Items that will be accepted include:

- Textiles / Clothes
- Good condition clothes to be collected separately.
- Torn clothes - including undergarments and rags; must be washed and packed separately.
- Electronics (all types of E-waste)
- X-ray films
- Used pens/ toys /stationary
- Empty tablet strips
- Glass bottles (in good condition)
- Books, Toys
- All types of plastics (washed & clean)
- Hard and soft.
- Footwear in pairs
- Cardboard & paper
- Bags
- Metal of all types
- Thermocol
- What is not accepted
- Mattresses & Pillows
- Broken Glasses
- Furniture and bulky items
- Wet and Heavily contaminated items
- Puja frames and puja items
- Hazardous and Medical waste

Collection points

- 1) RKNagarra
6/5, Tiruveedhiamman Koil St, Ramakrishna Nagar, Raja Annamalaipuram
Contact Bala at 7010848668
- 2) KARA - Karpagam Avenue Park
4th Street, Next to Pillayar temple , Karpagam Avenue, Raja Annamalaipuram
Contact Bindu Veerabahu at 9176776767
- 3) Poonga View RWA and Mandaveli Raja Street RWA

Outside Aishwarya ASpartments, 29 Raja street extension, Mandaveli, RAPuram
Contact Ravi Subramanian at 94440 76428/ Ganga Sridhar at 9940056069

Three apartments Ragamallika, Raghuvaramsh and Ganeshram in RA Puram are also participating in this drive as private collection points for their residents only.

The organisers have requested residents not to leave any waste after the drive is over at any of the drop locations

For details, call 9150003024/ 9940056069

EcoKconnectors and Spreco are back with another edition of its 'Resource Revival Drive' happening on September 27; 10 a.m. to 4 p.m. Aimed at the festival season, the drive encourages residents to not just clean their home but lend a hand to clean the planet.

The collection drive held in May 2026 saw 1,500 kg of waste collected and sent for responsible recycling. One can bring their old, unused resources a chance to be revived and recycled.

RAPRA's AGM today

On the sidelines of the annual general body meeting, there will be shopping facilitated by stalls put up by brands



From last year's AGM

Raja Annamalaipuram Residents Association (RAPRA) is conducting its 11th Annual General Body Meeting at Rajah Muthiah Boys Higher Secondary School in Srinivasa Avenue, R.A. Puram on September 20 (from 9.00 a.m. onwards). In this meeting members will elect their new office bearers, pass resolutions and fulfill the statutory obligations, says a press release from RAPRA.

Preceding this meeting Bank of Baroda will give a power presentation on their bank's schemes and N Gopaldaas Jewellers will give a presentation on diamond excavation and about the so-called "dosham" in

diamonds. Also on this occasion Lawrence and Mayo opticians will conduct a free eye testing for the visitors. The Government Horticulture Department will sell saplings, compost, seeds and garden tools, the press release notes.

Car dealers, textiles brands, jewellers and dealers of organic vegetables and condiments will put up stalls and sell their products. Stalls are open to the public and it is free. RAPRA will also distribute financial assistance to 40 school students belonging to neighbouring Chennai Schools and Government Aided schools, the release adds.

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At Lloyd's Road, traffic gets sluggish during the evening rush hour. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Wrong-side driving has gotten worse here

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

Navigating V. P. Raman Road, Lloyds Road, and Judge Jambulingam Road to reach Yellow Pages junction is one exasperating task. This is especially true during the evening rush hour.

K. Vimala Krishnamurthy, a motorist, says that ever since traffic from Royapettah High Road was diverted through V. P. Raman

Road and Lloyds Road to facilitate metro rail work on Royapettah High Road, reaching the junction is an ordeal.

Motorists driving down Radhakrishnan Salai to reach Royapettah High Road, Lloyds Road and V. P. Raman Road should take a U-turn at Citi Center and enter through Venkatachalam Road. But motorists drive through Judge Jambulingam Road.

M. Sharadha Mohan, a moto-

rist, says, "The traffic from Royapettah High Road to the Yellow Pages junction comes to a grinding halt due to wrong-side driving. To add to the chaos, vehicles are parked on the stretch. The situation continues till 10 p.m. No traffic police personnel are present to regulate traffic. The congestion is a daily thing and gets worse on wedding reception days."

Motorists on Radhakrishnan Salai can navigate through Venka-

tachalam Road, Sri Krishnapuram Street and enter Royapettah High Road to reach the stretches.

Along Jambulingam Road and Radhakrishnan Salai, motorists find it difficult to take a right turn due to wrong-side driving. "Motorists block the route," adds Sharadha.

G. Shankar, a motorist, says, "In addition Judge Jambulingam Road, wrong-side driving is ram-

pant on Venkatachalam Road, Jagadambal Colony First Street, and Chandrabagh Avenue First Street. Traffic police personnel should be posted at Judge Jambulingam Road and Dr. Radhakrishnan Salai, Judge Jambulingam Road and Chandrabagh Avenue First Street, Lloyds Road and Jagadambal Colony First Street and Royapettah High Road and V P Raman Road to curb wrong-side driving."



A thematic concert at Kapaleeswarar temple



On the auspicious occasion of Pradosham, the iconic Kapaleeswarar temple in Mylapore witnessed a special thematic concert, Aindhozhil Valaan, presented by Carnatic vocalist Rasiga Deviprasadh. According to a press release, the concert explored the five divine acts of Lord Siva: Srsti, Sthiti, Samhara, Tirobhava and Anugraha through a

carefully curated selection of compositions from different traditions of Tamil and Indian devotional music.

Rasiga commenced the concert with the invocatory composition "Prabho Ganapate" in Raga Tilang, attributed to the revered sage Agastya. This was followed by a vibrant Ganesha Namavali, which immediately drew the audience in-

to the performance, with the entire gathering joining Rasiga in singing.

Rasiga introduced the concept of Pancakrtya: the five cosmic acts of Lord Siva. This was followed by Tamil compositions spanning a full millennium, starting with Manikkavasagar and Tirujnana Sambandar, to Arunagirinathar, Gopalakrishna Bharati, and concluding

with a moving Tiruvarutpa by Raimalinga Adigalar.

The press release notes that Rasiga Deviprasadh was ably supported by Deviprasadh on the harmonium, Visswesh on the mridangam, and Jaya Hamsini on the violin. She was further supported vocally by her students Mathangi, Srinidhi, Aarohi and Srimathi.

Model youth parliament on September 27

The Candles is conducting a 'Model Youth Parliament' on September 27 at ICSA Hall, Egmore. Some of the topics one can register to participate include 'The Government vs Your Phone: AI, Privacy and National Security', 'One Nation, Same Rules: Should India have uniform laws', 'NEET and Big Coaching', 'Viksit Bharat by 2047 vs Net Zero by 2070: Can India achieve both', and 'The dark side of 10-min app'. Registration fee is ₹200.

For details, call 8248364496

Special buses to Tirumala

In view of Brahmotsavam at Sri Venkateswara Temple in Tirumala, the Tamil Nadu Government Transport Corporations are operating more than 100 special buses daily till September 30.

Passengers can book tickets on www.tnsc.in and on the Tamil Nadu State Transport Corporation official app.

Taking a shot at a rare avocation

Dealers of airguns in Chennai note that enthusiasts of recreational airgun target shooting are on the rise

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

A sharp crack followed by a silence probably lasting just a picosecond and therefore going unregistered, and then the loud pop of a balloon bursting from a pellet shot. Those sounds, in that sequence, are heard every day at Marina and Bessie. And usually, to create that sequence of sounds ten times on the trot, with the hire of an air rifle and a balloon target screen, a beach-goer would have to part with ₹50. There are those who seek to make this one-time indulgence a regular habit not by visiting the beach every day, but by a one-time visit to a shop selling airguns.

Welcome to the hobby of recreational airgun shooting which can be practised in a controlled environment at one's own private space. At Asian Air Guns on Perambur Barracks Road, Ashwin Kumar underlines that owning an airgun does not entail getting a license by meeting a fusillade of requirements. That said, there are still requirements to be met. One, the buyer has to be at least 18 years of age and offer proof of identity by presenting a copy of their Aadhar card or driving license. "Aadhar card is preferred," he emphasises.

Another requirement, something that cannot be met by the presentation of a photocopied document, is responsible behaviour. There is discretion to be followed while carrying an air rifle or air pistol. Brandish it in public, and you would find yourself on the wrong side of the law, the act being counted as a punishable offence. While being transported, the airgun has to be carried in a case, covered and hidden from

the public, Ashwin explains.

"When we sell an airgun, irrespective of the price at which it is sold, we take a primer on how to use it, which includes how to use it responsibly. We cannot expect everyone to know the dos and don'ts of it and hence the time, 30 to 45 minutes, we spend educating them," says Ashwin, adding that airgun literacy is indispensable given that target shooting enthusiasts are on the increase. A good number of them take up target shooting away from the glare of the sporting arena because of the quiet benefits it brings to the mind: focus and stress-busting rejuvenation. But an equally good number of them would be cutting their shooting tooth on airguns with the objective of eventually graduating to professional shooting, which involves get-

ting a license. Ashwin likens it to learning to ride a basic scooter before entering a bike race, "If you want to become a bike racer you first learn to ride an Activa."

Besides the logical learning process, there is also economy involved in taking it step by step. He elaborates: "Joining a shooting club and taking up advanced training would automatically lead someone to invest heavily in costly equipment. And what if someone discovers shooting is not their thing after making that investment? Airguns is a

cost-effective way for someone to find out whether shooting is for them or not." And even with an air pistol and air rifle, one could enter a competitive fray, nationally and internationally, as a category with 10M air rifle for men and women and air pistol for men and women exists.

Ashwin brings this perspective to table as he has been on the other side of the counter as well, as a buyer of shooting equipment for his own use, being a licensed shooter and a member of Chennai Rifle Club. In fact, he shares a passion

for shooting with his father S. Ramesh Balaji who established Asian Air Guns in 2005. Both father and son have made a comeback to the shooting range, the former after a 25-year hiatus and the latter, a 10-year break. But as for their business, they want to stick to selling just airguns.

Anna City Armoury also has a history etched with father-son teamwork. Located on Raja Muthiah Road in Periamet, the shop was started in 1993 by T. Selvamani, who had earlier worked with P. Orr & Sons. The "Armoury" in the enterprise's name signifies continuity in Selvamani's professional life. P. Orr & Sons had a link with the armoury business before being associated entirely with horology. The last embers of its identity as a manufacturer and seller of firearms were smouldering in 1967.

Anna City Armoury is run by Selvamani's son, S. Sivabalan, 49, who joined his father while pursuing his degree, and would go on to take over the business entirely after his father's demise in 2015. The shop deals in airguns as well as firearms that require license on the part of the buyer as well as the dealer. Sivabalan admits that the latter, that is selling airguns is the easier proposition. But that is not without its challenges either: one of them is that helped by technology, manufacturers sell directly to consumers with the result that the middle ground occupied by dealers has narrowed.

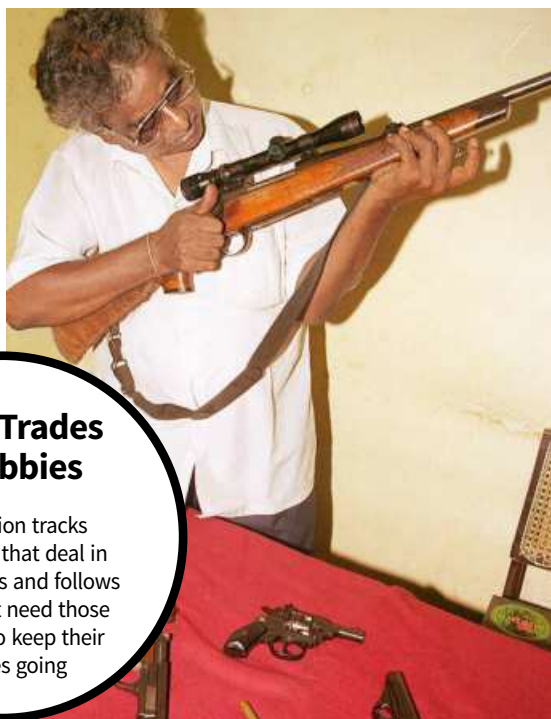


Airguns on display; airguns at a balloon popping shop in Marina; T. Selvamani founder of Anna City Armoury at Periamet; and Ashwin Kumar of Asian Air Guns at Perambur Barracks Road.



Niche Trades & Hobbies

This section tracks businesses that deal in rare products and follows groups that need those products to keep their hobbies going



Chennai's little Krishnas and Radhas steal the limelight

More than 1,000 children from across Chennai and the neighbouring districts of Kancheepuram, Tiruvallur and Chengalpattu participated in this edition of *The Hindu Downtown Maya Kannan*

Maya Kannan 2026 authored by *The Hindu Downtown* concluded on a joyous note with the grand prize distribution ceremony held at Gyan Bhawan Auditorium in AM Jain College, Meenambakkam on September 13.

The contest received an overwhelming response with the participation of more than 1,000 children from across Chennai and the neighbouring districts of Kancheepuram, Tiruvallur and Chengalpattu. As part of the Chennai edition which covers the KTCC districts, the contest was organised across five *Downtown* zones, with 13 winners selected from each zone, taking the total number of winners to 65.

The winners were shortlisted after careful evaluation by the jury, with performance, creativity and overall presentation being key considerations. The presence of several children dressed as little Krishna and Radha added a special charm to the occasion, making the selection process particularly challenging for the jury.

After the winners were finalised, they were invited to the prize distribution ceremony along with their parents and families.

The event became an opportunity not only to recognise the young winners but also to celebrate the encouragement and support provided by their families.

The programme began on a graceful note with captivating classical music and dance performances by the talented students of AM Jain School. Their well-presented performanc-

es added a cultural touch to the celebration and were thoroughly enjoyed and appreciated by everyone present. The guests who participated in the inauguration are: P. Suresh Chand Chordia, management committee member, A.M. Jain Educational Institutions, Gayathri, general manager, A.M. Jain Educational Institutions; Vinod Balaji, managing director, Narpavi; S. Ramalingam; insurance advisor and mutual fund distributor; Balaji, store manager, Poorvika Appliances.

The sponsors: The title partner

for the event was Gopuram Turmeric Powder & Kumkum, co presented by Dheepam Lamp Oil, Poorvika Appliances. Associate Partners for the event were Narpavi, S.Ramalingam, Insurance Advisor and Mutual fund Distributor and T.T. Asafoetida. The food partner was Cafe Coffee House, the venue partner was A.M.Jain College. Meenambakkam, Chennai, and the water partner was Repute Water. Gifts were sponsored by Hirlaptop.com. DIFA, Naga food products, P S Tamarind, RAS Chekku Oil, Vivekanandha Sarees and Priyadarshini Cell Universe.

From the event held at AM Jain College in Meenambakkam on September 13. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Winners of Mylapore zone



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S. VIDHUNA



SHRADDHA SRINIVASAN

CONSOLATION PRIZES

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R MUTHU PALANIAPPAN
SHIVANI MOHAN
JAI DHEV D.V
ANVIKA
R. TAKSHVI
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SRIVARAHAN S.
P.H. ADVAITH
SHREYAS RAM B



Two ends of the spectrum

Viraj Madappa, who won the Chennai Open, recalls his association with the city

BY A SPECIAL CORRESPONDENT

The Chennai Open golf title held at the TNGF Cosmo Course in Nandanam recently saw two golfers – Viraj Madappa and Mukesh Kumar – at two ends of the spectrum. While one has started his journey, the other is on the verge of saying goodbye to a sport he dominated like no other. The two players are

Viraj Madappa, the 28-year-old who clinched the title, was not the leader in the first three days. He played like a man possessed on the final day to defeat the overnight leader Ajeetesh Sandhu to win his first crown in Chennai and his fourth overall and take home a prize money of ₹ 15 lakhs.

Hailing from Kolkata and having learnt golf at Tollygunge Club (Kolkata), Madappa moved to Bengaluru in 2016.

“Chennai is special to me. My mom’s side-grandmother’s brothers live in Saidapet, and even my first sponsor, Dilip Thomas (of AV Thomas & Co. Ltd.) is from Chennai. It’s my first title here, and being able to make something happen is pretty special,” he said during the prize distribution function.

In fact, one of his relatives used to run a hotel called Vishranthi in Besant Nagar. It is no longer owned by his relative, but Madappa remembers eating naan and paneer butter masala there in his childhood.



Madappa heaped praise on the Cosmo Course. “It’s a short course. You don’t need to have a hole that’s 240 yards. So, I think Cosmo Course has a simple design but very, very effective.”

On the other side of experience

From the presentation function and (left) Mukesh Kumar



is Mukesh Kumar. The 62-year-old from Mhow, Madhya Pradesh, is one of India’s most successful and enduring professional golfers, holding a cult status on the domestic circuit. He is now at the fag end of his career and will play his last tournament in Raipur next week after winning 100 career titles on the domestic circuit.

“It’s been a great journey. I’ve had my successes and failures,” he said.

For Mukesh, the course in Nandanam has been tough, although as he has not won a title here. The vet-

eran, however, praised the maintenance of the course.

“Look at the conditions now—even after the rain, players are still playing. There is no waterlogging problem; their drainage system is incredibly good. The people who maintain this golf course have done a fantastic job,” he said.

Mukesh said that, given his age, he doesn’t have the strength and stamina to last longer. “At this stage, the young boys hit the ball very long. I have the experience, but I don’t have that power anymore.”

A young artist’s celebration of handloom tradition

Abiramapuram resident will showcase her latest works at a two-day exhibition starting on September 25



In August last year, she had presented 30 of her works on the ‘Art of Happiness’ in the city. Tarika, a resident of Abiramapuram, is the daughter of Srivats Ram, CMD, Wheels India. Ten-year-old Adhrush, a student at Shiv Nadar school, who has learned weaving on various looms including sari will also be exhibiting his works at the same venue on these two days.

The inauguration will take place at 11 a.m on September 25 and the exhibition will be open till 7 p.m. on both days. Taneira is located on Gandhi Nagar 1st Main Road, Adyar.

Nineteen-year-old Tarika will showcase a dozen of her newly-created handwoven tapestries at a two-day exhibition at Taneira in Adyar. Over the last year, she has been focusing on honing her weaving skills at Shuttles & Needles

and says that the exhibition is an artistic celebration of India’s rich handloom tradition. The 12 works have been inspired by South Indian sari patterns and colours. For over ten years, she has been mentored on art by her guru Diana.

Free computer education in Mylapore

Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan’s Gandhi Institute of Computer Education and Information Technology Centre in Mylapore imparts free computer education to the educated unemployed youth belonging to the economically backward section of the society. Bhavan is offering this selfless service to deserving students in various job oriented computer courses like

MS-Office with Tally, DTP, said a release. These courses have helped many students to secure employment at various levels. Senior citizens can now take Microsoft Word, Excel and Internet Courses. Last date for collection and submission of filled application forms is September 26. For more details contact in person. Phone: 24611312, 24643420

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An initiative to recycle clay Ganeshas started by Teynampet resident Malini Kalyanam has impacted many resident groups in Chennai and beyond. Under the aegis of The PALM, headquartered in Tiruvallur, the 'Beautiful Bharat — Save Clay' drive has found volunteer groups across Tamil Nadu

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL



Clay Ganeshas collected at SSM Nagar. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

but supply is on the lower side," she says. Malini says the recycling project has been around for nearly a decade, but awareness has picked up considerably in recent years. With more people asking what they should do with their idols after the festival, the initiative has gradually expanded into a larger conversation about responsible celebration.

Malini, a Teynampet resident who has shifted her base to Tiruvallur for running The PALM, notes that the clay Ganesha idols recycling initiative, titled "Beautiful Bharath — Save Clay" powered by The PALM, has grown bigger, being pan-Tamil Nadu now as volunteers from across the state, which includes P.S. Jayaraman of SSM Nagar, are chipping in. Malini notes plans are afoot to extend the initiative to cities such as Mumbai and Hyderabad.

An extended and green Ganesh Chaturthi

At SSM Nagar in Alapakam, New Perungalathur, residents have been having an extended Ganesh Chaturthi for the last three years, making the clay Ganeshas central to a recycling initiative. As in the previous two years, under an in-house initiative, 'KAATRU' (Keeping Awareness And Action Towards Recycling and Upcycling), helmed by P.S. Jayaraman, has collected clay Ganeshas and kept them ready for potters.

Residents are asked to choose natural, unpainted clay idols and, after the celebrations, leave them at a designated collection point near the Pillayar Kovil. From there, the idols are handed over to potters.

P.S. Jayaraman, a resident of SSM Nagar, initiated this exercise three years ago inspired by a newspaper article about how Malini Kalyanam, pottery artist and environmentalist. "She was in Teynampet. There was a newspaper article saying that Ganesha idols need not be put into water and cause pollution, and that they could instead be given back to potters," he says. The article prompt-

ed Jayaraman to contact Malini, after which the community arranged for its idols to be collected and sent to potters.

The arrangement changed in the second year, when Jayaraman began looking for potters who could directly collect them from the community. "I looked on Google and contacted four or five potters inside Chennai," he says. Eventually, a potter near Kovalam connected him with another potter in Mahabalipuram, who agreed to collect the idols and reuse the material. "From the second year onwards, we started sending the idols directly to him. Last time, we sent around 900 to 1,000 Ganesh-

as," Jayaraman says.

This year, around 200 to 250 idols had already been collected, with residents expected to continue bringing them in until the afternoon of September 19. Jayaraman has also been urging residents to think about their choices before the festival. The campaign asks them to avoid Plaster of Paris idols, non-eco-friendly paints and decorations. "I have been talking only about clay. I have been telling them not to buy painted Ganeshas or plaster Ganeshas," he says.

For Malini Kalyanam, who is Director of the Artistic Pottery Training Academy in Kattupakkam and

one of the founders of The PALM, a public charitable trust, the issue goes beyond what happens to an idol after the festival. As a pottery artist, she has also watched the availability of natural clay decline. This year, her academy received enquiries from corporates as well as members of the public looking to purchase clay for Chaturthi workshops, only to find it difficult to source.

"This year we had enquiries from corporates and the public alike to purchase clay for Chaturthi workshops, and that is when they said it is not available online or even at shops in the locality. This shows that demand is high

An alternative application

Malini Kalyanam notes that if a collection facility or a potter is not available, the clay from the Ganesha idols can be used in tree-planting exercises. She suggests placing the idol in a bucket of water and letting it break down over a few days. Once the clay settles into a powder, it can be reused. However, Malini says, the clay should not simply be poured around a plant or sapling and expected to act as element of nourishment. For it to support plant growth, it needs to be mixed with other materials. She lists the ingredients that mixed with the clay that has dried up as a powder and found impressive results: garden soil, compost, perlite or sand, mushroom molasses and water. The ratio of the ingredients would depend on the sapling, she notes.

DAC launches luxury residences

DAC Developers, one of the city's leading construction companies, recently launched an ultra-luxury residential apartment project, Balmandaisa, on St. Thomas Mount-Poonamallee Road.

At the launch, the company held a logo-revealing ceremony at its Balmandaisa office.

The residential project offers expansive residences, premium amenities and strategic connec-

tivity. It has 194 residences, offering two-and three-bedroom apartments and four-and five-bedroom duplex residences. The residences are complemented by a standalone ground-plus-three-floor clubhouse spanning 10,000 square feet, said a release.

The project comprises two basement levels, stilt, and 13 residential floors, creating a well-integrated residential

community.

The homes are priced from ₹1.19 crore, added the release.

Sathish Kumar Santhanam, founder and managing director, DAC Developers; Kumar Vembu, founder, Mudhal Partners Private Limited and co-founder, Zoho; Hari Vignesh R, senior relationship manager, construction finance; Aditya Birla Housing Finance Limited, and Manjunath Selvamani, regional

sales manager, Prime Home Loans, Aditya Birla Housing Finance Limited, took part.



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